

Interview Conflicts with Other Judges

When you want to interview a specific project, at the start of the interview period you will normally walk up and introduce yourself to the student. On occasion, another judge will be there already speaking with the student, or another judge will arrive while you are speaking with the student. Here we address such conflicts.

Who Else Speaks with the Students?

There are only two kinds of judges who will be present in the project display area during the interview periods:

1. **Grand Award Judges.** You are a Grand Award Judge because you and your fellow judges will determine your category's Grand Awards. All judges in your category are identifiable by two colored ribbons hanging from their name badges that will be identical to the two ribbons hanging from your own name badge.
2. **SAO Judges**, also known as Special Award judges. (SAO stands for Special Award Organization.) These judges are working for external organizations which are giving their own awards based on their own criteria and will usually interview projects in multiple categories. SAO Judges are identifiable by a red ribbon hanging from their name badges.

Other than judges and the finalists themselves, only ISEF staff will be present in the display area, but they will never compete with you for interview time. At most, ISEF staff (or your co-chairs) may speak with students while the students are waiting for you to arrive. On occasion, ISEF staff may interrupt an interview, but they will quickly move on.

Interview Opportunities

On Tuesday, after you register, and on Wednesday between 6:00 and 7:40 am, you can review the project displays, but no students will be present.

On Wednesday, between 7:40 am and the start of Interview Period 1 at 9:30 am, you should not be in the Exhibit Hall. Instead, you should be attending the meeting with your fellow Grand Award Judges in your category's caucus room. This time is reserved exclusively to SAO judges.

There will be a total of 20 interview periods during which Grand Award Judges are able to interview ISEF finalists. You will receive your personal interview schedule in two installments. The first, at Registration on Tuesday, will assign you to interview 13 projects in the first 18 interview periods. The second, assigned shortly after 1:00 pm on Wednesday, will give you two final interviews during periods 19 and 20.

During some of your 5 scheduled breaks, you can choose to interview projects with which you are not scheduled. Using your breaks in this way is entirely your choice.

Grand Award judges are not allowed to interview any student except during one of the 20 interview periods. In particular, there are no interviews allowed during the lunch break.

Interview Priority – The Point of This Document

On Wednesday, before the start of Interview Period 1 at 9:30 am, SAO judges have absolute priority in interviewing ISEF finalists. During this time, you should not attempt to speak with any ISEF finalist.

During the 20 scheduled Interview Periods comprising the rest of the day, a *fair-scheduled interview* gives you absolute priority over all other judges to speak with the scheduled project. No other judge should attempt to interview the same project during your scheduled period.

In all interview periods where no Grand Award judge is scheduled to speak with a given project, conflicts should be resolved by a “first-come first-served” policy. This applies regardless of whether you have a conflict with another Grand Award Judge or an SAO Judge.

No judge may preempt another by subterfuge, such as writing his or her name in an empty slot of a student’s printed schedule. Only *fair-scheduled interviews* convey priority to any judge.

Finally, no judge should ever attempt to weasel their way into any other judge’s *fair-scheduled interview* by interrupting or by standing so close as to eavesdrop on the interview. Your priority for speaking with a scheduled project is important and should not be usurped.

Schedule Violations

Occasionally a judge will extend their scheduled interview beyond the end of their scheduled time, infringing upon your scheduled time. This is not allowed. Your scheduled time is yours. After informing the other judge that it is now your time, if he/she does not leave quickly, please check that judge’s name and inform one of your category co-chairs so that they can deal with the problem. They will appreciate knowing of the incident and will keep track of such behavior, especially in case it repeats in other interview periods affecting more of your fellow judges.

Points of Emphasis

1. Grand Award Judges who are scheduled to interview a project in a given interview period have absolute priority over all other judges during that scheduled period.
2. When a project has no scheduled interview, all judges have equal priority and should respect a “first-come first-served” policy. Judges cannot preempt others by writing their name on a student’s printed schedule.
3. Grand Award Judges should not be present in the Exhibit Hall between 7:40 am and 9:30 am when SAO judges have priority.